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Microsoft Corp. (MSFT.O)

Azure and CoPilot Drive Another Strong Q1 Acceleration

CITI'S TAKE

Microsoft delivered another inflection in Q1. A broad-based beat was once again driven by AI-enabled upside in its most strategic businesses Azure and M365 Commercial Cloud. These both delivered larger than typical upside and reaccelerating growth with an impressive 6 pt acceleration in Azure. Importantly, the top-line strength continues to come with disciplined capital allocation with COGS $s in line with guidance as MSFT Cloud GMs improved 1pt QoQ, while opex and capex both lower than forecast which drove EPS comfortable ahead of expectations. We look to the 530PM ET conference call for guidance and additional detail on the CoPilot momentum (Seats vs. consumption), and broader capex/AI commentary. We expect shares to extend gains and anticipate a solid Q2 guide ahead of consensus.

Agents and Infra Strength Driven by Azure and M365 Cloud — Agents & Infra revenue of $76.8B grew 25% y/y cc, 1.6% above consensus, 1.2% above CitiE, and above prior guidance of $75.15–75.75B, accelerating 3pts from 22% cc in F4Q26. Azure grew 48% y/y cc, ~3pts above consensus, well ahead of the 44–45% guide and accelerating 6 pts from last Q. M365 Commercial Cloud grew 19% cc, ~210bps above consensus and ~70bps above CitiE, accelerating from 15% cc in F4Q26. This was driven by Copilot, E5/E7 and GitHub Copilot ARPU uplift, though M365 commercial seat growth slowed to 5% from 7%.

Devices and Consumer — Devices & Consumer revenue of $15.5B declined 3% y/y cc but was 3.2% above consensus, 3.9% above CitiE, and above prior guidance of $14.7–15.2B. Windows OEM and Devices declined 22% y/y. That was in line with CitiE but ~160bps below consensus and at the low end of the 20–22% decline guide. The company attributed it to lapping Windows 10 end-of-support demand, OEM/channel inventory drawdowns and weaker PC demand. The upside instead came from Search & advertising ex-TAC (+12%) and a narrower XBOX content and services decline (-1% cc vs -10% in F4Q26).

EPS (US$)	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4	FY	FC Cons	VA Cons
2026A	4.13A	4.14A	4.27A	4.81A	17.34A	17.28A	17.28A
2027E	**4.81E**	**4.91E**	**4.98E**	**5.29E**	**20.00E**	**19.75E**	**19.75E**
Previous	4.81E	4.91E	4.98E	5.29E	20.00E	na	na
2028E	**5.69E**	**5.86E**	**6.03E**	**6.46E**	**24.04E**	**23.55E**	**23.53E**
Previous	5.69E	5.86E	6.03E	6.46E	24.04E	na	na
2029E	**7.07E**	**7.31E**	**7.61E**	**8.18E**	**30.16E**	**29.04E**	**28.64E**
Previous	7.07E	7.31E	7.61E	8.18E	30.16E	na	na

Source: Company Reports and dataCentral, Citi Research. FC Cons: First Call Consensus. VA Cons: Visible Alpha Consensus.
Click here for Visible Alpha consensus data

Buy	
Price (28 Oct 26 16:00)	US$531.01
Target price	US$636.00
Expected share price return	19.8%
Expected dividend yield	0.7%
Expected total return	20.4%
Market Cap	US$3,943,507M

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See Appendix A-1 for Analyst Certification, Important Disclosures and Research Analyst Affiliations

Implications — Against elevated expectations, we think Microsoft delivered on both top/bottom lines with meaningful accelerations in their most strategic businesses. We expect shares to extend gains and anticipate a solid Q2 guide ahead of consensus. We look to the 530PM ET conference call for guidance and additional detail on the CoPilot momentum (Seats vs. consumption), and broader capex/AI commentary.

Figure 1. F1Q27 Results vs Citi & Consensus Expectations

Financial Metrics	Citi (Before)	Reported (GAAP)	Reported vs. Citi	Consensus	Reported vs. Cons.	Guidance	Comments:
Q1 FY27E	*in millions, except where per share*						
Agents and Infra	$75,867	$76,795	1.2%	$75,661	1.5%	75,150 - 75,750	Driven by Azure and M365 Commercial Cloud
% Y/Y	*23.0%*	*24.5%*	*150bps*	*22.7%*	*184bps*	22% - 23%	
% Y/Y CC	*23.6%*	*25.0%*	*144bps*	-		21% - 22%	
Azure	$32,416	$33,165	2.3%	$32,843	1.0%	-	
Azure % Y/Y cc	***45.4%***	***48.0%***	***264bps***	***44.9%***	***314bps***	**44% - 45%**	**Accelerated 6pts Q/Q**
M365 Commercial Cloud % Y/Y cc	***17.3%***	***19.0%***	*168bps*	***16.7%***	***228bps***	**17% - 17%**	
Devices and Consumer	$14,910	$15,484	3.9%	$15,021	3.1%	14,700 - 15,200	Driven by Search and XBOX
% Y/Y	*(6.8%)*	*(3.2%)*	*359bps*	*(6.1%)*	*289bps*	(8%) - (5%)	
Windows OEM + Devices % Y/Y cc	***(22.2%)***	***(22.0%)***	*23bps*	***(20.4%)***	***(161bps)***	(20%) - (22%)	
Total Revenue	**$90,777**	**$92,279**	1.7%	**$90,578**	1.9%	89,850 - 90,950	FX impact <1pt, below expectations
% Y/Y	*16.9%*	*18.8%*	*193bps*	*16.6%*	*219bps*	15.7% - 17.1%	
% Y/Y CC	*17.2%*	*19.0%*	*176bps*	*17.5%*	*146bps*	14.7% - 16.1%	
Cost of Revenue	$29,753	$29,720	(0.1%)	$29,722	(0.0%)	29,600-29,800	
Gross Profit	**$61,024**	**$62,559**	2.5%	**$60,791**	2.9%	60,250-61,150	
% margin	*67.2%*	*67.8%*	*57bps*	*67.1%*	*68bps*	67.1%-67.2%	
Microsoft Cloud GM%	***65.1%***	***66.0%***	***90bps***	-		**~65%**	Decreased 1pt YoY driven AI Infrastructure + AI product
Operating Expenses	$16,815	$16,644	(1.0%)	$16,801	(0.9%)	16,800-16,900	
Operating Income	**$44,210**	**$45,915**	3.9%	**$43,990**	4.4%	43,450-44,250	
% margin	*48.7%*	*49.8%*	*106bps*	*48.6%*	*119bps*	48.4%-48.7%	
EPS - NON-GAAP Diluted	**$4.81**	**$4.89**	1.6%	**$4.73**	3.5%		Excluding OpenAI Impact
EPS - GAAP Diluted	**$4.89**	**$4.92**		-			
CapEx	$41,926	$39,367	(6.1%)	**$46,933**	(16.1%)		~2/3's short-lived assets
Total CapEx (+ Cap Leases)	$51,000	$45,200	(11.4%)	**$51,680**	(12.5%)		DC Finance Lease of $7.4B
% Y/Y	*46.1%*	*29.5%*	*(1,662bps)*	*48%*	*(1,857bps)*		
Commercial Bookings Growth		***(11.0%)***					Healthy growth in commercial sales motions

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Source: Citi Research, Company Reports, FactSet, Visible Alpha

Figure 2. F2Q27 Citi Estimates vs Consensus and Expectations

$ in millions, except per share	Next Quarter						
	Citi	Cons.	Expectations	Citi vs Cons.	Citi	Cons.	Citi vs Cons.
	2QE	2QE		Δ	FY2027E	FY2027E	Δ
Agents and Infra	$79,945	$79,513	***79,712 - 80,308***	$432	$334,211	$331,092	$3,119
% growth y-o-y	*24.1%*	*23.4%*	*24% - 25%*	*67bps*	*24.6%*	*23.5%*	*116bps*
% growth q-o-q	*0.0%*	*5.1%*					
M365 Commercial Cloud	$26,904	$25,700		$1,204	$110,262	$106,600	$3,662
% growth y-o-y	*14.2%*	*9.1%*		*511bps*	*18.4%*	*14.5%*	*393bps*
Azure	$35,290	$35,041			$149,543	$147,470	
% growth y-o-y	*46.3%*	*44.7%*		*160bps*	*46.7%*	*43.0%*	*368bps*
% cc growth y-o-y	***46.3%***	***45.5%***	***45-46% cc***		***46.9%***	***44.6%***	*233bps*
Devices and Consumer	$15,814	$15,816	***15,658 - 15,816***	($2)	$60,778	$61,910	($1,132)
% growth y-o-y	*-8.9%*	*-6.0%*	*-7% - -6%*	*(289bps)*	*-7.1%*	*-2.8%*	*(429bps)*
Total Revenue	$95,759	$95,575	***95,097 - 96,053***	$184	$394,989	$391,000	$3,989
% growth y-o-y	*17.8%*	*17.6%*	*17% - 18%*	*23bps*	*19.0%*	*15.1%*	*390bps*
% y-o-y growth acceleration	*1.0%*	*1.0%*					
% cc growth y-o-y	*17.8%*	*13.1%*			19.3%	14.5%	
Cost of Revenue	$32,257	$32,432			$133,375	$132,818	
Gross Profit	$63,502	$63,143	*62,512 - 63,143*	$359	$261,613	$258,182	$3,431
% margin	*66.3%*	*66.1%*	*~66%*	*25bps*	*66.2%*	*66.0%*	*20bps*
% y-o-y margin expansion	*(172bps)*	*(197bps)*			*(171bps)*	*(191bps)*	
Operating Income	$45,363	$44,673		$691	$185,045	$181,193	$3,852
% margin	*47.4%*	*46.7%*	*47-48%*	*63bps*	*46.8%*	*46.3%*	*51bps*
% y-o-y margin expansion	*28bps*	*(35bps)*			*7bps*	*(44bps)*	
EPS - Diluted NON-GAAP	$4.91	$4.84		$0.07	$20.00	$19.67	$0.33
FCF	($2,062)	$60		($2,121)	$18,482	$28,081	($9,599)
% margin	*-2.2%*	*0.1%*		*(222bps)*	*4.7%*	*7.2%*	*(250bps)*

Note: We note expectations for items in the report we expect to be most significant in moving the stock on earnings

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Source: Citi Research, Company Reports, FactSet, Visible Alpha

Microsoft Corp.

Valuation

Our $636 one-year target price for Microsoft is based on ~23x PE multiple to our FY29 GAAP EPS of $30.16, which we discount back to a year forward using ~12% cost of equity. We see the EPS multiple as a better valuation metric due to the more stable earnings growth for a mature company like MSFT and the ramp in near-term CapEx that result in a more volatile FCF.

Risks

We see potential downside risks to achieving our target price to be:

• The aggressive ramp in CAPEX investment in midst of the ongoing build out of AI capabilities could hurt longer term trajectory if AI adoptions are slower than expected.
• Competition in the hyperscale cloud market, requiring MSFT to aggressively invest here vs. AMZN's AWS and GOOGL's GCP and potentially fast deceleration in key Azure trajectory.
• A larger acquisition that drives earnings dilution in the nearer term.

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Appendix A-1

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Microsoft Corp. (MSFT)

Ratings and Target Price History
Fundamental Research

Analyst: Tyler Radke



	Date	Rating	Target Price	Closing Price
1	25-Oct-23 11:53:13	1	*432.00	340.67
2	24-Jan-24 04:37:03	1	*470.00	402.56
3	31-Jan-24 04:45:50	1	*480.00	397.58
4	18-Apr-24 03:56:23	1	*475.00	404.27
5	26-Apr-24 02:55:25	1	*495.00	406.32
6	20-Jun-24 22:14:02	1	*520.00	445.70
7	31-Jul-24 03:28:04	1	*500.00	418.35
8	23-Oct-24 05:32:01	1	*497.00	424.60
9	17-Apr-25 07:29:30	1	*480.00	367.78
10	15-May-25 04:04:19	1	*540.00	453.13
11	11-Jun-25 06:00:18	1	*605.00	472.62
12	22-Jul-25 06:13:39	1	*613.00	505.27
13	31-Jul-25 05:26:20	1	*680.00	533.50
14	21-Oct-25 21:28:14	1	*682.00	517.66
15	30-Oct-25 04:29:33	1	*690.00	525.76
16	21-Jan-26 07:28:07	1	*660.00	444.11
17	29-Jan-26 05:17:03	1	*635.00	433.50
18	21-Apr-26 03:33:50	1	*600.00	424.16
19	30-Apr-26 04:58:49	1	*620.00	407.78
20	15-Jul-26 05:44:43	1	*570.00	395.63
21	30-Jul-26 05:10:50	1	*600.00	451.10
22	14-Oct-26 06:43:51	1	*636.00	533.69

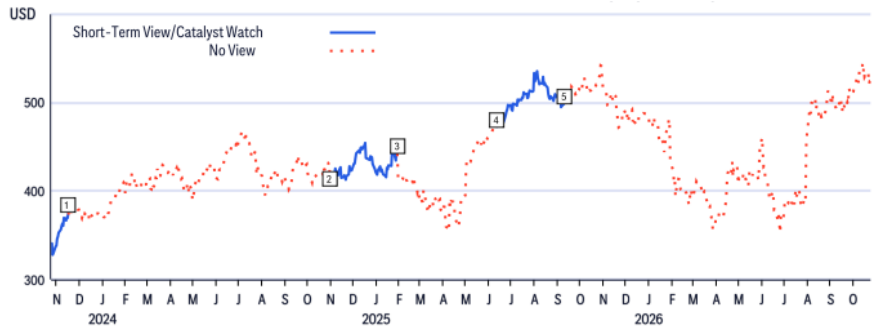
*Indicates Change

Rating/target price changes above reflect Eastern Time

Microsoft Corp. (MSFT)

Short-Term View/Catalyst Watch Research

Analyst: Tyler Radke



	Date	Action	Expected Direction	Duration	Closing Price
1	16-Nov-23 23:18:55	Remove CW	Upside	90 Days	376.17
2	31-Oct-24 00:00:10	Add STV	Upside	90 Days	406.35
3	29-Jan-25 11:14:18	Remove STV	Upside	90 Days	442.33
4	11-Jun-25 02:00:18	Add CW	Upside	90 Days	472.62
5	09-Sep-25 12:02:03	Remove CW	Upside	90 Days	498.41

CW - Catalyst Watch , STV - Short-Term View

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